



SCORPION IN THE FROG POND

Rulebook

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Game Overview

Deep in the heart of an ancient forest lies the Frog Pond, steeped in mystery and magic! Here, all kinds of frogs gather to grow berries, bake delicious treats, and unlock the secrets of the pond to activate their ancient frog abilities. But among these frogs is a scorpion who can kill with a single strike! Find your allies and team up to defeat the scorpion! -Or perhaps betray your friends if the scorpion's and your goals align...

In **Scorpion in the Frog Pond**, each player takes on the secret role of one of 8 **Character Cards**, each with their own private agenda.

Throughout the game, players gather **Resource Cards** to complete **Recipe Cards**, earning points that allow them to draw **Ancient Ability Cards**- A mix of spells and potion cards that offer an equal amount of power and insight. Each player's hidden identity restricts which spells they can cast, eliminating potential suspects as spells are activated. But don't wait too long to strike! The more spells the scorpion can cast, the stronger they become.

Table of Contents

Game Overview	Page 1
Table of Contents	Page 2
Objective	Page 3
Definitions	Page 4
Components	Page 5-8
Setup	Page 9-11
Gameplay	Page 12-16
Potions in the Berry Patch	Page 17-18
Ancient Ability Cards	Page 19-20
Ending the Game	Page 21-22

Objective

The game ends the moment the Poison Card is used. It may kill a player, or they may be immune if they've managed to acquire the Antidote Card. Either way, players then reveal their secret identities at the conclusion of the game to determine who has fulfilled their hidden win condition.

With each **Character Card** featuring their own win condition, the pond may see a single victor or an alliance of winners.

For the Frogs to claim victory, they must identify and collaborate with their fellow frogs, dissuade members of their allegiance from falling into Scorpion tactics, and protect their suicidal Rain Frog companion.

Definitions

Reference this section if any terms used throughout this booklet become confusing or need clarification.

Ancient Ability Cards: Both Spells and Potions.

Potions: One of 4 special **Ancient Ability Cards**.
Identifiable by their potion bottle art.

Spells: Any non-potion **Ancient Ability Card**.

Hand: A Hand consists of any **Resource Cards** and **Ancient Ability Cards** in a player's possession.

Frogs: Any **Character Card** that includes "Frog" in their name, including the Rain Frog.

Berry Patch: The 9 cards in the center of the table.

Components

Inside your copy of **Scorpion in the Frog Pond**, you will find everything needed for 3–8 players to scavenge, deduce, and deceive their way to victory:

There are 4 types of cards:

8 Character Cards

Each represents a unique hidden role with its own win condition and special ability.

Includes:

- Scorpion
- Poison Frog
- Tree Frog
- Wood Frog
- Glass Frog
- Bull Frog
- Horned Frog
- Rain Frog

50 Recipe Cards

Lists combinations of resources needed to complete concoctions, along with point values reflecting difficulty.

93 Resource Cards

The basic currency of the pond, used to complete recipes.

Includes:

- 15 Sugar
- 15 Flour
- 12 Huckleberry
- 12 BlackBerry
- 12 Strawberry
- 12 Raspberry
- 10 Honey
- 5 Bark

*Note on Bark Cards: Bark is not used in any recipes and cannot be traded. Incredibly rare, but useless to most frogs.

29 Ancient Ability Cards

A mix of Spells and Potions unlocked by spending points earned from recipes.

Includes 25 Spell cards and these 4 Potions:

- Poison
- Antidote
- Truth Serum
- Love Potion

*All Spell cards listed on next page.

Other contents:

Optional Logic Table Notepad:

Tear-off sheets for tracking deductions, suspicions, and card play- especially useful in games with many players.

Action Exchange: x5  You may trade any number of Ancient Ability Cards from your hand, including this one, for an equal amount of new ones. Shuffle the traded cards back into the Ancient Abilities deck.	Elite Forager: x1  Declare any of the 4 Berry cards aloud. Draw from the Resource deck until you draw that card, keeping all the resources drawn. Stop if you draw a total of 15 cards.	Revealer: x1  Flip over every face-down card in the Berry Patch. You may now move 3 cards from the Berry Patch to your hand, replacing them face up from the Resource Deck. In this case, you are safe from Potion effects.
Action Surge: x1  Play this card on your turn to take an additional 2 actions.	Frog Charm: x2  Force a player to play one of their Ability cards. They may only play cards with their symbol as usual. However, in this case the Poison is playable for them.	Scorpion's Claw x1  When played, everyone with a potion must raise their hand. You may draw another card from the Ancient Abilities deck.
Compost Bin: x1  Discard any Resource cards for 1 point each, 2 points for any Berry Resource cards.	Joint reward: x1  When any players share a recipe, you may play this card out of turn to claim the full point value of that recipe.	Scramble: x1  Ignore the number requirement on a Recipe card. You now need only one of each required resource for that recipe.
Deflect: x2  Deflect any effect played on you to a player of your choice.	Keen Sight: x1  Look through another player's hand OR the next 10 cards in the Ancient Abilities deck. You may rearrange these cards.	Spirit Link: x1  Allow a player of your choice to look through the next 5 cards in the Ancient Abilities deck and give you a card of their choice. Shuffle the Ancient Abilities deck after.
Diversion: x2  Steal up to 3 cards at random from another player OR take all 9 cards from the Berry Patch. You are not safe from Potion effects. Reset the Berry Patch after.	Love Retrieval: x1  Look through the Ancient Abilities deck or discard pile and take the Love potion. If it is not there, this card does nothing. Shuffle the Ancient Abilities deck afterwards.	Truth Retrieval: x1  Look through the Ancient Abilities deck or discard pile and take the Truth Serum. If it is not there, this card does nothing. Shuffle the Ancient Abilities deck afterwards.
Double Up: x1  When completing a recipe, double the point value you would receive.	Quick Draw: x1  Play this card at any time to take an action out of turn.	

Setup

Before the pond can descend into scheming and secret plots, follow these steps to prepare the game for play:

1. Assign Roles with the **Character Card** deck:

Adjust for player count:

If you have 8 players, simply shuffle and deal one **Character Card** to each player face down.

If you have fewer than 8 players, set the Scorpion aside temporarily as it must always be included. Then randomly remove **Character Cards** until you have exactly as many cards as players. Remove those **Character Cards** from the game without revealing what they are. Finally, shuffle the Scorpion back into the remaining cards before dealing.

Players may look at their own card before laying it face down in front of them, keeping it hidden from other players.

2. Deal Starting Hands

Shuffle the **Resource Deck** thoroughly.

Deal 5 **Resource Cards** to each player as their starting hand.

Any **Resource Cards** and **Ancient Ability Cards** in a player's possession is a part of their hand.

Character Cards and **Recipe Cards** are not considered a part of a player's hand.

3. Create the Berry Patch

Lay out 9 **Resource Cards** face up in a 3x3 grid at the center of the table. This is called the *Berry Patch*.

The *Berry Patch* serves as a shared pool of resources that players can interact with on their turn, swap cards into, or secretly manipulate to deceive others. More on the *Berry Patch* in the next section: **Gameplay**

Place the **Resource Deck** and **Recipe Deck** next to the *Berry Patch* in reach of all players.

Place the **Ancient Abilities Deck** in the designated spot on top of the Game Box.

4. Deal Starting Recipes

Shuffle the **Recipe Deck**.

Deal 3 **Recipe Cards** face up in front of each player.

These are public; everyone can see what **Recipe Cards** you are trying to complete.

Final Checks!

Make sure each player has:

- 1 face-down **Character Card**
- 5 **Resource Cards** in hand
- 3 face-up **Recipe Cards**
- Ensure the *Berry Patch* is set up in the center.
- Place the remaining **Resource Deck**, **Recipe Deck**, and **Ancient Abilities Deck** within reach of all players.

Gameplay

The game proceeds in turns, allowing only one action at a time.

Play starts with whoever ate berries last, and proceeds clockwise.

Turns are designed to be quick, so don't fret if you don't accomplish all you wanted in one round. It'll be your turn again before you can say Huckleberry pie!

Turn Overview

On your turn, you may choose **one** of these **five** actions to perform:

1. Draw a card
2. Trade with another player
3. Interact with berry patch
4. Complete a recipe
5. Play an Ancient Ability Card

1. Draw a Card:

Draw from the **Resource Deck** and add it to your hand.

2. Trade with Another Player:

Two or more players may agree to exchange cards from their hand. Below are the rules of trade:

- Trades may be hidden from the table, but they must be honest.
- You may trade any number of **Resource Cards** and/or **Ancient Ability Cards** from your hand for any number in return. You do not have to match the number or type of cards to trade.
- Donations are **not** acceptable trades. All parties must offer at least one card to trade.
- Elderberries are **not** tradable cards. They may, however, be swapped in the *Berry Patch*.

3. Interact with the Berry Patch:

The *Berry Patch* supplies players with cards in two main functions: **Swap** or **Draw**.

Swap: Take a face-up card from the *Berry Patch* and place a card from your hand face down in its place. When you do this, you must announce aloud what card you are placing down, but you may lie.

Or

Draw: Take a face-down card from the *Berry Patch* (placed there by a previous swap) replace that card with one from the **Resource Deck**, face up.

*Note! When drawing face-down cards from the *Berry Patch* you are not required to swap a card from your hand.

Ancient Ability Cards and **Resource Cards** are both valid to **swap** in the *Berry Patch*. If any Spell cards or **Resource Cards** are drawn from the *Berry Patch* it is acquired as normal. Potions, however, function differently when drawn from the *Berry Patch*.

***See Potions in the Berry Patch on page 17 ***

4. Complete a Recipe

Reveal and discard the required **Resource Cards** from your hand that match one of your **Recipe Cards**.

Score the points shown on the **Recipe Card**, then discard it.

Players may collaborate with any number of players to complete a recipe. Negotiate how you'll divide up the point total achieved.

Draw a new **Recipe Card** to replace it so you always have exactly three.

Refreshing Recipes

- At any time, even outside of your turn, you may discard all three of your current **Recipe Cards** to draw three new ones.
- This can only be done once per turn cycle, and you must discard all three at once.
- This does not count as your normal action.

5. Play an Ancient Ability Card

Play a Spell card from your hand and resolve its effect, if your **Character Card** allows (determined by the icons on the Spell card).

Play a potion, if your **Character Card** allows. Love potion and Truth serum can be played by anyone.

*Note! Some Spell cards can be played out of turn when specified on the card. These cards do not use an action to play.

Using Spells

- **Ancient Ability Cards** are held in your hand alongside **Resource Cards**.
- Each Spell Card shows which characters are allowed to play it by icons on the card- if your character's icon is crossed out, you cannot play that card.
- You may trade or swap any **Ancient Ability Cards** into the *Berry Patch*.

*Note! Action Exchange is a Spell card that all characters can use to swap **Ancient Ability Cards** for new ones.

Potions in the Berry Patch

When drawing from the *Berry Patch*, normally whatever card you draw goes safely to your hand. However, if you draw one of the four potion cards, you reap the effects of it before discarding the potion. Potion effects are as follows:

Poison: When drawing the Poison from the *Berry Patch*- you are poisoned and the game ends, unless you are the Scorpion. In that case, the Scorpion safely possesses the Poison.

Antidote: When drawing the Antidote from the *Berry Patch*- you are now immune to poison and the Antidote is removed from the game, unless you are the Horned Frog. In that case, the Horned Frog now possesses the Antidote.

Truth Serum: When drawing the Truth Serum from the *Berry Patch*- you must turn your Character Card face up for the duration of the game and place the Truth Serum in the discard pile, unless you are the

Glass Frog. In that case, the Glass Frog now possesses the Truth Serum.

Love Potion: When drawing the Love Potion from the *Berry Patch*- you must discard the Love Potion and one Spell card you can play, if you have one, and reveal to the table what it was. Do not reap the benefits of that Spell card. The Bull Frog, however, does not need to discard a Spell card. In that case, the Bull Frog now possesses the Love Potion.

Ancient Ability Cards

As you complete **Recipe Cards**, you earn points, representing your growing skill in crafting and uncovering the pond's ancient magic! That magic is realized in the form of the **Ancient Abilities Deck**. Each time a player reaches 10 points, they must draw from the **Ancient Abilities Deck**.

For example:

If you complete a Honey Crisp **Recipe Card** worth 23 points, while at 0 points, you would draw 2 **Ancient Ability Cards** (for reaching 20), and keep 3 leftover points toward the next threshold.

Playing Ancient Abilities

Ancient Ability Cards are held in your hand alongside your **Resource Cards**.

On your turn, you may use your action to cast a Spell, resolving its effect immediately.

*Note! Some spells specify they may be played outside of your turn.

Who can use which abilities?

Each Spell card lists all 8 Character icons with certain icons crossed out.

If your Character's icon is crossed out, you cannot cast that spell.

You may still trade it, swap it in the *Berry Patch*, or use an Action Exchange Spell (which all Characters can play) to swap unwanted **Ancient Ability Cards** for fresh ones.

*Note on the Glass Frog:

If the Glass Frog uses Truth Serum to adopt another Character's win condition and special ability, they still only play Spell cards where the Glass Frog symbol (G) is not crossed out. Potions, however, become playable in the same way as their new special ability allows.

Ending the Game

The building tension and excitement of the pond can end in an instant. The game concludes immediately once the Poison card is used.

When that happens, all players simultaneously reveal their **Character Cards**, exposing their true identities.

Players then resolve who has met their win conditions, based on the final state of the pond.

Example

If the Scorpion successfully poisons the Tree Frog, the Scorpion wins for causing any frog's death, while the Wood Frog also wins because the Tree Frog was killed (one of the Wood Frog's possible conditions).

Meanwhile, the Rain Frog would not win, because they survived. Nor would the rest of the frogs as not all frogs survived.

If instead, the Scorpion poisoned the Rain Frog, then only the Rain Frog would win.

Strategy

The Scorpion thrives when they act early and often. Don't hesitate to strike! Casting spells is your path to power. Even if your identity becomes obvious, the right spell at the right moment can tip the game beyond recovery. Hesitation is often more dangerous than exposure.

For the Frogs, coordination is everything. Identifying the Scorpion is only the first step, stopping them is another matter entirely. Share suspicions, watch for patterns, and act together. A lone Frog is easy prey.

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With the rules revealed and the pond's mysteries before you, all that remains is to play. Tread carefully through its shadows, weave your alliances wisely, and note each secret uncovered. For when the final ripples fade, it is up to you to determine who will be left standing!